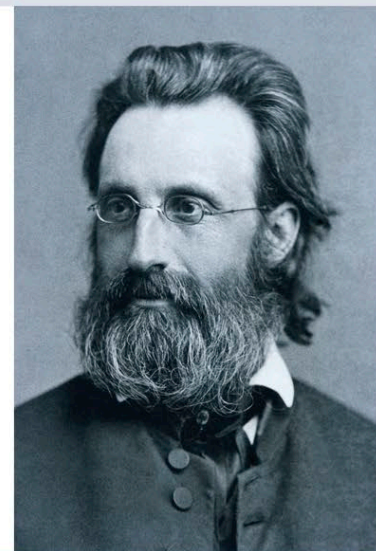




ANDREW JACKSON DAVIS (1826–1910)

The Poughkeepsie Seer

A particular influence on John Murray Spear (see below) was Andrew Jackson Davis, an American clairvoyant, spirit-channeler, and mesmerist healer. He was an early practitioner of spiritualism, nicknamed the “Poughkeepsie Seer” after he developed his true calling in the town of that name. Davis drew heavily on Swedenborg’s ideas (see opposite) and in turn probably influenced writers such as Edgar Allan Poe. He claimed to channel special wisdom in works such as *The Principles of Nature*, *Her Divine Revelations*, and *a Voice to Mankind*, which he dictated while in a trance.



◀ Sisterly séances

Once they became celebrities, the Fox sisters’ séance repertoire included such marvels as moving objects and levitating tables. This 19th-century print depicts a séance that they held in Rochester, New York, in 1850.

America, England, and France. However, some people were skeptical about the Foxes, and Maggie once stated that their work was all a hoax (only to later recant this). It is now widely believed that they produced the raps by cracking bone joints, and that they were in fact charlatans.

Messiah machine

Another spiritualist episode occurred in the 1840s: American Universalist minister and human rights campaigner John Murray Spear experienced strange visions, which led him to explore spiritualism. Universalism, a product of the American Enlightenment, centered on salvation for everyone. Guided by spirit voices from beyond the grave, allegedly including that of Benjamin Franklin, Spear built a utopian machine that would supposedly bring eternal redemption and leisure for all. In 1854, spiritualist newspaper *The New Era* announced the “New Motive Power” machine’s completion, at the then-astronomical cost of around \$2,000. Spear’s project ultimately fell foul of skepticism and failed, but the spiritualist ideas behind it had made their mark.